

Yes, if we hold good dividend-paying stocks, our income is hedged even if markets fall due to macro shocks. Public sector stocks are among the best hedges for investor portfolios.

▶▶▶

You've often said private companies should share profits more fairly. Any plans to nudge them?

Only via moral suasion. We don't plan any coercion. Research shows that 30–40% payout is a fair share of dividends. Dividends belong to

investors; reserves belong to promoters. Our in-house research shows that public sector stocks statistically dominate Nifty50, and this is well-recognised by institutional investors and funds. We believe private companies will align as expectations rise.

▶▶▶

What big-ticket sales are in the pipeline for FY26?

We started the year with an OFS in April. Market conditions are improving, and we plan to come out with more OFS regularly

in small tranches. This helps retail investors participate meaningfully, which is also the finance minister's guidance.

▶▶▶

Does the OFS mechanism favor institutions over retailers? How are you addressing this?

Yes, institutional investors tend to move faster. This year, we'll keep a green shoe option so that retail and small investors get a fair share. We'll also provide forward guidance via DIPAM's official channels.

▶▶▶

What about the much-awaited LIC FPO?

We've already done 3.5% disinvestment in LIC. The government remains committed to increasing its market float. The work is ongoing, and you'll hear good news soon. But as you know, no market participant shows all his cards—so, wait for the moment.

▶▶▶

Let's address the elephant in the room—loss-making PSUs. What's the road map?

The new public sector policy identifies few strategic sectors where government presence is essential—like energy, transport, defense, critical minerals, etc. In other sectors, the private sector has come off age. Based on inter-ministerial reviews, certain public enterprises are being identified for closure, consolidation, or strategic disinvestment. All of this encourages greater private participation.

▶▶▶

Given global uncertainties, could Budget numbers for disinvestment and dividends be revised upward?

We met our targets last financial year and have set higher ones for this year. We're pushing public enterprises to improve performance and expect to achieve both higher dividends and asset sales this year. **BT**

@tweettokarishma

PHOTO BY RAJWANT RAWAT

